What the research says

AI makes you feel faster.

But is it making you better?

The answer depends on how you use it.

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Feeling fast isn’t the same as being fast.

Research lab METR ran a randomised trial: 16 experienced developers, 246 real tasks on their own projects.

What they expected	**24% faster**
What they felt afterwards	**20% faster**
What was measured	**19% slower**

Fair note: this used early-2025 tools. METR’s 2026 follow-up leans towards a speed-up, but METR says that data is too unreliable to give a number.

Sources: METR, July 2025 study & Feb 2026 update

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The hidden cost: learning.

Anthropic tested 52 developers, mostly junior, learning a new coding library. Then everyone took a quiz on it.

50%

average quiz score with AI help

67%

average score for those who coded by hand

The biggest gap was in **debugging**: spotting when code is wrong, and why.

And the time saved? Too small to count as a real difference.

Source: Anthropic, "How AI assistance impacts the formation of coding skills", Jan 2026

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It’s not the AI. It’s how you use it.

In the same study, people who used AI in different ways got very different quiz scores.

HANDED IT OVER

Let AI write it, or kept asking it to fix the errors

24–39%

STAYED CURIOUS

Asked AI “why?”, asked for explanations, asked about the concepts

65–86%

Same tool. Same task. Very different learning.

Source: Anthropic skill-formation study, Jan 2026 (quiz scores by way of using AI)

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The pros use AI a lot. And they check it.

Stack Overflow's 2026 survey of 30,000+ developers in 169 countries:

4 in 5 use AI tools at work

~1 in 2 trust AI's output when they can easily check it

6.6% would trust it with an important decision

Checking AI takes skill. And skill has to be built.

Source: Stack Overflow Developer Survey 2026 (published Oct 2026)

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Two ways to use the same AI.

Skipping

Copy, paste, ship

“Just fix it” on repeat

Accepts the first answer

Can’t explain their own work

Growing

Tries first, then compares

Asks “why does this work?”

Questions the answer

Can explain it in their own words

Both get the work done today. Only one is still getting better next year.

Which one are you on most days?

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5 habits to grow with AI.

1. **Try it yourself first**
   Then use AI to compare, not to start.

2. **Ask “why?” after every answer**
   The answer helps today. The “why” stays with you.

3. **Fix some errors on your own**
   In the study, the no-AI group hit 3× more errors, and learned debugging from them.

4. **Explain it back**
   If you can’t explain it, you don’t own it yet.

5. **Check before you ship**
   Fast and wrong is still wrong.

Save this for your next task.

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Let AI do the work.
Don’t let it do your learning.

Anyone can get speed now. Judgment is something you still have to build.

Do you feel faster with AI, or have you actually measured it?

Tell me in the comments.

Repost if this helps someone who’s learning.

Repost